



WEEK TWO · MODULE TWO

The Words You Will Never Hear

The confidential note on the codes of luxury

THE PRIVATE CONCIERGE ACADEMY

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CONTENTS

Contents

I	The words you will never hear in a luxury setting
II	The grammar of understatement
III	The nine seconds
IV	What to do when you do not know
V	The codes nobody writes down
VI	Case law: five people, and what gave them away
.	Glossary · Self-assessment

HOW TO STUDY THIS MODULE

This note is not a vocabulary list. It is what a person learns after two years inside a house, and usually after two humiliations.

Read it slowly, and read it against yourself. Almost every rule here exists because someone, somewhere, was quietly never asked back.

Where an exact sentence is given, learn it by heart. You will not have time to compose one.

CHAPTER I

The words you will never hear

And what saying them announces about you

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Eliminate the vocabulary of the outsider from your speech, permanently.

Understand what each forbidden word actually reveals.

1.1 · The mathematics of the word

The more a person says "luxury", the further they are from it. You will hear that sentence again in your session, because it is the most portable thing I can give you. It works on brands, on people, on hotels, on other candidates, and on yourself.

The reason is structural. To describe a world, you must be standing outside it and pointing at it. The people inside do not point. They name, precisely, and then they stop.

The word	What saying it announces
Luxury	That you are looking at this world from a shop window.
Exclusive	That you have been excluded, and are still thinking about it.
VIP	That you work somewhere that sorts people into tiers, and tells them which tier they are in.
Iconic	That you read the caption rather than the object.
Prestigious, high-end, upscale, premium	That you have read the brochure. These four words appear on no invitation, in no household, and in no serious conversation.
Amazing, incredible, stunning	That you are surprised. Being surprised by nice things is the clearest possible signal that you are not accustomed to them.
"To be honest with you"	That the rest of the time you are not.
"No problem"	That there might have been one.

THE REPLACEMENT, AND IT IS ONE WORD

Certainly.

It closes, it commits, it asks for nothing, and it contains no emotion whatsoever. It is the most useful word in this profession, and you can begin using it today.

CHAPTER II

The grammar of understatement

How to say that something was extraordinary

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Speak in the register of the house: precise, brief, unemotional.

Convert enthusiasm into observation.

You will need, one day, to say that something was very good. Here is how it is done, and how it is not.

The outsider says

The professional says

"It was an amazing evening."

"It went well." Or, if it truly did: "It was a very good evening."

"The chef is incredible."

"The chef is excellent. You would like him."

"That wine was stunning."

"That was drinking beautifully." Or nothing, and a small nod.

"I finally managed to get the table."

"It is arranged."

"It was really difficult, but I sorted it."

"It is done."

"You look absolutely stunning."

Nothing. You do not comment on the principal's appearance. Ever.

Notice the direction of travel in every line: **from emotion to fact, and from length to brevity.** That is the entire grammar of this world, and it takes most people a year to hear it, and another year to speak it without effort.

THE RULE THAT GOVERNS ALL OF IT

Never explain how hard it was.

The effort is the thing you are paid to absorb. Handing it back to them, in the form of a story about your afternoon, is handing back the very thing they bought.

CHAPTER III

The nine seconds

What is read about you before you have spoken

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Eliminate the physical tells that precede your first word.

Understand that none of this will ever be mentioned to you.

Long before your vocabulary is tested, a great deal has already been decided. Not consciously, and not unkindly. It is simply how humans read one another, and in a closed world the reading is faster and less forgiving.

- **Your scent.** If it entered before you did, you have already spoken, and you have spoken loudly.
- **Your hands.** They will be near a plate, a child, a document. They are looked at far more than your face.
- **Your shoes, including the heel.** An ancient reflex, and it has not weakened.
- **Any logo.** A logo says: this object was expensive, and I would like that noted. It is the exact opposite of every code in this module.
- **Sound.** Bracelets, heels on stone, keys, a bag that rustles. You must be able to enter a room without being heard.
- **Your telephone.** On a table, it is a small flag announcing that something more interesting may arrive at any moment.

And the most important of all, which is not a thing you wear but a thing you do: **stillness**. Fidgeting, adjusting, shifting your weight, checking, smoothing, touching your hair. Every one of these reads as anxiety, and anxiety in the staff makes a family anxious, which is the precise opposite of what you were hired to produce.

CHAPTER IV

What to do when you do not know

The most valuable page in this module

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Handle a reference you do not recognise, without bluffing and without embarrassment.

Convert ignorance into credit.

4.1 · Why the bluff is fatal

A name is mentioned. A château, a designer, a school, a village, a vintage, a family. You do not know it. Every instinct will tell you to nod, to smile, to say "of course".

Do not. The world you are entering is extremely small, and the person speaking has usually known the subject for thirty years. Your bluff is detected almost instantly, and it does something far worse than reveal a gap in your knowledge: **it reveals that you are willing to pretend.** And a person who will pretend about a wine will pretend about an expense, an error, or a message they forgot to pass on. That is the inference, and it is made in silence, and it is never revised.

THE EXACT WORDS

"I don't know it. Tell me."

Four words. No apology, no explanation, no self-deprecation, and no anxiety.

They will tell you. People enjoy explaining what they love, and you have just given them the pleasure of doing so. You will leave that conversation better regarded than the person who nodded, and you will also, incidentally, know something new.

4.2 · The three ways this goes wrong

- **The apologetic version.** "Oh gosh, I'm so sorry, I really should know that." You have now made your ignorance into an event, and asked them to reassure you. Never ask a principal to reassure you.
- **The deflecting version.** "Ah yes, I've heard of it." This is a bluff wearing a coat.
- **The over-correcting version.** Going home, reading for two hours, and mentioning it pointedly the next day. That is a display, and displays are the error. If it comes up naturally in a month, you will simply know it.

CHAPTER V

The codes nobody writes down

The small things that decide a great deal

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Absorb the conventions that appear in no book and are never explained.

- **Never comment on the value of anything.** Not the art, not the watch, not the car, not the house. Not to admire it. Especially not to admire it. Noticing the price of things is the clearest signal that one is unaccustomed to them.
- **Never photograph anything.** The table you laid beautifully. The view. The dish. The photograph that ends a career is almost never malicious; it is proud.
- **Never repeat a compliment you were given by a guest,** to the principal. It reads as a request for credit, and credit is the one thing you must never appear to want.
- **Do not laugh at a joke that is not funny.** Warmth, yes; performance, never. They can tell, and it makes them tired.
- **Do not touch.** Not an arm, not a shoulder, not a child's head. In a great many houses, and a great many cultures, this is not a preference. It is a line.
- **Never be the last to leave a room** if the family are still in it, unless you are working in it.
- **Eat before service, never during, and never standing in a doorway.**
- **Learn the names of the staff before you learn the names of the guests.** The staff will decide your first month; the guests will not remember you at all.
- **Say less than you want to. Then say less than that.**

AND ONE THAT IS WORTH MORE THAN THE REST

Never let a principal see you calculate.

Not the cost, not the time, not the effort, not whether it is worth it. The visible hesitation before you answer, the small breath before you say yes: that is the moment they feel themselves become a burden, and no one ever forgets being made to feel that.

CHAPTER VI

Case law

Five people, and the thing that gave them away

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Recognise the shape of a code failure before it is yours.

The candidate who said "luxury"

The situation. A very strong candidate, twelve years in five-star hotels, excellent references, interviewed for a lifestyle-manager role in a Geneva household. In forty minutes she used the word "luxury" nine times, and the phrase "high-end clientele" twice.

The lesson. She was not selected, and the family could not have told you why. The consultant could: every use of the word placed her outside the room she was asking to enter. She was describing their life to them, as a brochure would.

The one who admired the watch

The situation. A house manager, three weeks in, admiring a watch on the principal's wrist, said warmly: "That is a beautiful piece. Is it the new one?"

The lesson. Nothing was said. But he had just demonstrated that he knew what it cost, that he had been looking, and that the object interested him. **Never notice the value of anything.** The correct response to a beautiful object in a private house is no response at all.

The one who explained

The situation. A concierge who had spent six hours rescuing a dinner after a chef cancelled, and who told the principal, in some detail, what she had done to save it.

The lesson. The principal thanked her warmly, and never asked her to arrange a dinner again. **She had handed back the effort.** The correct sentence was: "It is arranged." Nothing more, ever.

The one who bluffed

The situation. Asked whether she knew a small château in the Loire, she said "of course, it's wonderful". The principal, who had grown up ten kilometres from it, asked a friendly follow-up question.

The lesson. It took nine seconds. He never mentioned it, and he never trusted a word she said again. **The bluff does not reveal a gap.** It reveals that you are willing to pretend, and that inference travels to everything else you touch.

The one who was heard

The situation. A guest-relations manager, excellent at her work, whose bracelets could be heard before she entered a room, and whose perfume remained in it afterwards.

The lesson. She was moved, gently, to a role with less contact with the family. Nobody told her why, and she believed it was a promotion. **In this world, you must be able to arrive without announcing yourself.** Everything else is negotiable. That is not.

Glossary of the module

Understatement · The governing register. From emotion to fact, from length to brevity.

The tell · A small act of self-display that identifies an outsider in seconds.

The bluff · Pretending to recognise a reference. It reveals not ignorance but willingness to pretend.

"Certainly." · The correct answer to almost any request. Closes, commits, contains no emotion.

"It is arranged." · The correct account of a difficult afternoon. Nothing more, ever.

"I don't know it. Tell me." · The four words that save a career, and occasionally build one.

Self-assessment

1. Explain, in your own words, why saying "luxury" places you outside the room.
2. Convert these into the professional register: "It was an amazing evening." "The chef is incredible." "I finally managed to get the table." "It was really difficult, but I sorted it."
3. A vintage is mentioned that you do not know. Give your exact words, and then give the three wrong versions and why each fails.
4. Why is a visible logo a code failure? Answer in terms of what it announces.
5. What is the single thing you must never let a principal see you do, and why is it unforgivable?
6. Of the nine unwritten codes in Chapter V, which two are hardest for you? Be honest.

ÉMILIE'S NOTE

Reserved. This is where I add what I saw, in my own words.

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